Riva Rodrigues

Computer Engineering

Company: UBS

Job Profile: Graduate Trainee

Offer Type: Internship + Placement

Internship Stipend: 60k

CTC: 14.5 LPA (12.5 + 2)

Location: Pune / Hyderabad

Process Date: 10/07/25 (PPT + OA)

14/07/25 (Interviews)

Placement Process:

1. Online Assessment
2. Technical Round
3. HR Round

1. **Online Assessment** + **UBS Campus Hackathon**

In March 2025, I participated in the **UBS Campus Hackathon** selection process, which began with an **online assessment** consisting of 50 minutes of multiple-choice questions and a coding problem. The MCQs focused on **Java** and core **computer science fundamentals** such as data structures, OOP, operating systems, and databases. The **DSA problem** varied for each candidate mine was on the easier side, and I was able to solve it successfully, passing all test cases and completing the assessment early.

Following the results, 11 students from our college were shortlisted to participate in the hackathon. Teams were randomly allocated, and I was initially nervous since all my teammates were complete strangers. But it turned out to be a great way to connect, collaborate, and step out of my comfort zone. Our problem statement was about addressing the shortage of teachers in Zilla Parishad schools by creating a smart platform to connect them with volunteer educators, a solution that helped our team win **2nd runners-up** at the hackathon.

One of the best parts of the hackathon was how supportive and involved the mentors and UBS professionals were. They were really friendly, easy to talk to, and genuinely wanted us to do well. We had regular check-ins with them, and they gave us helpful feedback on everything from our idea to how we presented it. If you're participating, **make the most of those interactions,** ask questions, share your progress, and take their suggestions seriously. It’s not just about improving your project, but also about learning how things work in the real world and understanding what companies like UBS look for.

As a finalist, I also received a **direct exemption from the UBS campus placement online assessment**, which allowed me to proceed straight to the interview round.

2. **Technical Interview** [20 candidates were shortlisted]

So, my UBS **technical interview** began on a pretty comfortable note. The interviewer asked me to introduce myself, and then we dove straight into my **internship experience and projects**. He seemed genuinely interested not just in what I had done, but also in the problems I was trying to solve, the features I had built, and my overall thought process. One of my projects was based on workflow automation, which led to an interesting discussion about the human-in-the-loop concept and where automation should be balanced with human oversight.

He also asked me about the **UBS hackathon project**, which I had mentioned on my resume. We discussed the problem statement and what I personally contributed to the project. Then he asked if I had used **AI in any of my projects**, and we had a short conversation about that as well.

After that, he moved on to ask about my **10th and 12th qualifications**, which I hadn't included on my resume. It was a bit unexpected, but the flow was smooth and conversational, so I didn't feel nervous.

I had about 4 days to prepare for the interview, and based on seniors' experiences, I expected questions mostly around **internships, projects, and CS fundamentals**. So I focused my prep on those areas. But right in the middle of the interview, the interviewer surprised me by saying, *"I'll be asking you 3 puzzles now."* That definitely caught me off guard, because I hadn't focused much on puzzles during my prep — apart from just reading the ones mentioned in previous interview experiences.

Puzzle 1: The Candle Puzzle (link)

He asked: "You have 2 candles and a matchbox. Each candle takes exactly 1 hour to burn. How can you measure 45 minutes?" My first thought was to break one candle in half, but he pointed out that wouldn't give an accurate 30 minutes. After asking for a hint, he told me, "The middle of the candle is the key." That's when I realized I could burn the first candle from both ends, making it burn out in exactly 30 minutes. At the same time, I'd light the second candle from one end. When the first one finishes, I'd then light the other end of the second candle, making it burn in 15 minutes, totaling 45 minutes. He appreciated the logic and said I had cracked the tough part well.

Puzzle 2: The Poisoned Bottle Problem (link)

This one was trickier. He said: "You have 1000 bottles, one is poisoned. You have 10 test strips, and results take 24 hours. How can you identify the poisoned one?" I wasn't sure of the exact approach but suggested dipping strips in multiples (2, 3, etc.). He said I was thinking about grouping but wouldn't be able to narrow it down precisely. He then gave a hint "Label the bottles" and asked me about bits. I realized he was referring to binary encoding, and I mentioned that I could assign a unique binary number to each bottle. But even with that, I couldn't fully figure out the logic. Before moving on, I asked if he could explain it. At first, he said no, but eventually, he shared the solution which was based on checking the bit pattern of the test strip results after 24 hours to pinpoint the poisoned bottle.

Puzzle 3: The Bridge Crossing Problem (link)

Before this one, he told me "You'll be able to crack this," which somehow made me feel more pressured. The problem: "Four people need to cross a bridge. They take 1, 2, 5, and 10 minutes. Only two can cross at a time, and they need a torch to cross. What's the minimum time to get all across?" I tried pairing the slowest with the fastest, with the fastest returning which gave me a total of 20 minutes. But he said the optimal answer was 17 minutes. I explained that my idea was to always have the fastest person return with the torch. He said I was thinking in the right direction, but I still couldn't land on the right sequence. He eventually explained it, and honestly, looking back, it seems so simple now. But in the moment, when you're under pressure, even the simplest things feel difficult if you're not calm.

At the end of the interview, I asked him two questions: one about what sets UBS apart technologically compared to other banks, and another about his own experience having spent 24 years in the investment banking sector, what made him join UBS and stay. He answered both very thoughtfully, sharing insights into UBS's strong tech-first mindset and what stood out to him compared to other firms he had worked at. It felt less like a formal Q&A and more like a genuine, engaging conversation and with that, the interview wrapped up.

Tips:

- **Stay calm.** Interviews can be nerve-wracking, but your ability to think clearly under pressure is just as important as your technical skills.
- **Know your projects well.** Be ready to explain why you made certain decisions, not just what you did. You should be able to defend your choices confidently.
- **Think out loud.** Don't go completely silent while solving problems. Share your thought process; it helps keep the conversation going and shows how you approach challenges.
- **Be honest if you're stuck.** It's okay to ask for a hint or say you're not sure, what matters is how you handle the situation.

Note: For some candidates they took multiple technical interviews, while for some they took a technical & just an HR interview only

3. **HR Interview** [10-11 candidates where shortlisted]

The HR interview was quite short and honestly felt more like a friendly conversation than a formal interview. The interviewer was from the Mumbai branch, and since I had already interacted with her during the UBS Hackathon, she remembered me, which immediately made things more relaxed and comfortable.

She started by asking whether I had participated in any other hackathons after the UBS one. I shared that I had, and she asked me to talk about the differences I noticed between those experiences and the UBS hackathon. After that, she briefly revisited my hackathon experience at UBS, asking how I found it overall. We then moved on to a basic background check. She asked about my family and whether I was planning to pursue higher studies like a master's degree (I said no). And that was it we wrapped up in under 10 minutes.

6 students were offered the role and I was one of them (5/6 were hackathon finalists).

Useful Tips:

1. **Strong DSA skills are crucial** to clear the online assessment. The difficulty of the DSA question can vary for each company and candidate, so be well-prepared. Personally, I practiced by solving the **Striver Sheet** and participating in a few **LeetCode contests**, which helped a lot.

2. **Know your resume inside out.** Be clear about what you've done, *why* you did it, and be ready to **justify your decisions**, whether it's a project, internship, or any achievement you've mentioned.

3. **Grab every opportunity** that comes your way whether it's a hackathon, competition, or learning experience. You never know which one might open the next door for you.

4. **Keep a smile on your face.** It sounds simple, but it goes a long way. Whether things are going great or feel uncertain, a smile helps you stay positive and confident and it reflects in your energy during interviews.

Resources I followed:

1. DSA: Striver's A2Z DSA Sheet
2. SQL: SQL 50
3. DBMS: Complete DBMS in 1 Video (With Notes) || For Placement Interviews
4. OOPS: https://whimsical.com/object-oriented-programming-7kyfM6D7AuURC6W3ESqD9t
5. OS and CN: Refer to GeeksforGeeks
6. Platforms like GeeksforGeeks and InterviewBit are great for practicing recently asked questions in CS fundamentals.

I know these processes can be mentally tough especially when things don't click right away. For some, it happens in the first attempt; for others, it takes a bit longer and a lot more effort. But what truly matters is that you **don't give up**.

If you have any specific questions, please feel free to reach out on LinkedIn

All the best for your placements!